

The Good Son

Psychological Horror Game

Game Design Document

Version 1.0

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Game Overview

Genre: Psychological Horror

Engine: Unreal Engine 5

Platform: PC (Windows)

Perspective: First Person

Dev Time: ~6 Months

Team Size: Solo Developer

The Good Son is a first-person psychological horror game where you play as a 7-year-old boy trying to survive life with his abusive stepmother. Rather than relying on jump scares, the game builds tension through atmosphere, environmental storytelling, and a unique **anxiety meter** system. The tagline: *"He doesn't have health. He has anxiety."*

Story & Narrative

You are a young boy trapped in a house with your violent stepmother. Your real mother is gone. Every night, you must survive her rage, complete tasks she demands, and find moments of safety. The game explores themes of childhood trauma, fear, and survival through environmental storytelling, notes scattered around the house, and escalating nightly events.

- Non-linear narrative revealed through collectible notes and environmental details
- Multiple endings based on player choices and anxiety management
- Escalating tension across a multi-night structure

Core Mechanics

Anxiety Meter System

Instead of a traditional health bar, the player has an **anxiety meter**. Anxiety increases when the stepmother is nearby, when hiding in dark places too long, or during scripted events. If anxiety maxes out, the player has a panic attack — causing visual distortion, heavy breathing, and potential detection.

Night Survival Mechanic

- Each night has tasks the player must complete while avoiding the stepmother
- Dynamic AI patrols — the stepmother's behavior escalates each night
- Hiding spots, distractions, and environmental interactions for evasion

Interaction System

- Pick up, inspect, and use objects in the environment
- Light switches affect visibility and anxiety levels

- Door mechanics — locking, peeking, and barricading
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Visual & Audio Design

- Atmospheric lighting — dynamic shadows, flickering lights, volumetric fog
 - Custom 3D assets modeled in **Blender** for the entire house environment
 - Post-processing effects: vignetting, chromatic aberration during high anxiety
 - Emissive materials for eerie ambient glow effects
 - Sound design: creaking floors, distant footsteps, muffled dialogue, heartbeat audio cues
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Technical Implementation

Unreal Engine 5

Blueprints

Blender

AI Behavior Trees

Lumen Lighting

Nanite

Post-Processing

Sound Design

- AI stepmother using **Behavior Trees** — patrol, investigate, chase states
 - Blueprint-driven anxiety system with UI feedback and camera effects
 - Lumen global illumination for realistic, dynamic lighting
 - Custom interaction framework built entirely in Blueprints
 - Modular level design for efficient iteration
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Links

 **Announcement Trailer:** youtu.be/QXttFf6VVmk

 **Making-Of Devlog:** youtu.be/19UZMaWnGFY

 **Portfolio:** [Back to Portfolio](#)